

Rob grew up on a farm in western Canada. His father was a professional farmer who raised dairy and grew produce. Wait a minute—am I saying a millionaire had parents who were simple *farmers*? That’s right. In fact, you’re going to see that several of the millionaires featured in this book come from farm backgrounds. Remember, these aren’t trust-fund babies; they’re normal people. Of all the millionaires that participated in our research, we found that the most common occupations of their parents were sales, farming, engineering, small-business ownership, and accounting. Notice titles like vice president of global operations or chief executive officer aren’t in that list. You’ll see later that most everyday millionaires—along with their parents—never had job titles like that themselves.

But let’s get back to Rob. With a wife and six children to provide for, his father was a hard worker—and he expected his kids to work hard, too. The family always had *enough*, Rob recalls, but they never had any *extra*. For example, Rob says they always had food to eat, but there were several Christmases without many gifts. He got one new pair of pants to wear to school each year, and those pants became work clothes at the end of the school year. Any minute he wasn’t in school or studying, Rob was working the farm with his family.

He took this intense work ethic to college, where he developed a passion for learning. Of course, his family had no money to send him to college, so he was on his own financially. He worked hard every summer to pay the next year’s tuition bills, and he worked during the school year for living expenses. Forced to manage his money so carefully, Rob developed a lifelong commitment to saving money. Today, when people ask him his secret to building wealth, he falls back on one of the first financial principles he ever learned: basic saving. “If you spend more than you make,” he says, “you will never get rich.” According to Rob, it’s just as important to get a good education. Rob didn’t let his poor farm background keep him from pursuing a degree. In fact, his passion for learning ultimately led him to complete several, including a law degree. From that point, Rob enjoyed a long career practicing law and teaching in local colleges.

Despite a good income as an attorney, Rob and his wife always prioritized saving and never spent money foolishly. He kept his cars an unusually long time, driving his last one for more than twenty years. Before any purchase, Rob has always asked himself, *Do I really need this?* If the answer is no, he doesn’t buy it. That kind of financial discipline has enabled Rob to amass a fortune of more than \$3.5 million throughout his working life. This is something he thinks anyone can do if they set their minds to it and avoid the two sins that he says steal people’s wealth-building potential: trying to keep up with their neighbors and waiting too late to start saving for retirement. “I never excused my spending by saying, ‘I’m only young once,’” he explains. “Instead, I said, ‘I’m only going to be old once—and I want to enjoy it.’”

Throughout his career, Rob built his wealth through simple, commonly available investments. He took advantage of his company’s investing plan as soon as it became available, and he put the rest of his investing dollars into retirement plans and mutual funds. He never received an inheritance either. Every dollar of his fortune is the result of his own hard work, careful planning, and financial discipline. That’s a recipe he says anyone can use to become a millionaire.
